

1800–1900

FANCY DRESS CHARADES

Fancy dress parties enabled the late Georgians and Victorians to have fun with dressing up. Like a game of charades, partygoers had to guess who their fellow guests were dressed as. Esoteric costumes absorbed influences from history, mythology, theatre, literary characters, and the Orient, reworked by dressmakers in imaginative and extravagant ways. Some partygoers wore costumes that family members had brought back from abroad, or retrieved treasured ancestral outfits from the attic. Others were inspired by sources such as Arden Holt's 1887 catalogue of *Fancy Dresses Described*, which was sold through Debenhams and Freebody's the department store. These featured fancy dress costumes as diverse as a foppish *Incroyable*, a witch, and a hornet. Natural materials such as beetle-wing cases and butterfly wings, and even live fireflies in net bags, were used to create a suitable macabre or exotic atmosphere.

ROYAL DRESSING UP



England's 1897 Devonshire House Ball was themed around allegorical or historical costume pre-1820. The Duke of York went as the 3rd Earl of Cumberland, with embroidered Genoa velvet pourpoint, sleeves and mantle, steel gorget (plate armour collar), crimson velvet trunks, high boots, and felt hat with three feathers. The Duchess was Marguerite de Valois, in pale blue satin, with a Medici old lace collar, and copious pearls and diamonds.



Middle Eastern This 1830 figure wears a Persian-style, knee-length vest of metal thread over a white lawn shirt and under a rich blue tunic trimmed with gold braid. Vandyking (zigzag borders) often indicated fancy dress in the 19th century.



Masque costume This couple from 1803 are in masquerade dress, with eye disguise. The woman wears an exotic Middle Eastern sash and the hem of her dress is hand-embroidered. He wears a Late Tudor-style jerkin and padded trunk hose.



Antique brocade The Eglinton Tournament of 1839 was a romantic extravaganza with medieval jousting and banquets. This lady, shown in her costume for the Scottish event, wears a Queen Henrietta Maria-style dress with a silk brocade overdress.